

Psalms 71

Hope from Youth to Old Age

Thou art my hope, O Lord God: thou art my trust from my youth

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *In thee, O LORD, do I put my trust: let me never be put to confusion.*
- 2 *Deliver me in thy righteousness, and cause me to escape: incline thine ear unto me, and save me.*
- 3 *Be thou my strong habitation, whereunto I may continually resort: thou hast given commandment to save me; for thou art my rock and my fortress.*
- 4 *Deliver me, O my God, out of the hand of the wicked, out of the hand of the unrighteous and cruel man.*
- 5 *For thou art my hope, O Lord GOD: thou art my trust from my youth.*
- 6 *By thee have I been holden up from the womb: thou art he that took me out of my mother's bowels: my praise shall be continually of thee.*
- 7 *I am as a wonder unto many; but thou art my strong refuge.*
- 8 *Let my mouth be filled with thy praise and with thy honour all the day.*
- 9 *Cast me not off in the time of old age; forsake me not when my strength faileth.*
- 10 *For mine enemies speak against me; and they that lay wait for my soul take counsel together,*
- 11 *Saying, God hath forsaken him: persecute and take him; for there is none to deliver him.*
- 12 *O God, be not far from me: O my God, make haste for my help.*
- 13 *Let them be confounded and consumed that are adversaries to my soul; let them be covered with reproach and dishonour that seek my hurt.*
- 14 *But I will hope continually, and will yet praise thee more and more.*
- 15 *My mouth shall shew forth thy righteousness and thy salvation all the day; for I know not the numbers thereof.*
- 16 *I will go in the strength of the Lord GOD: I will make mention of thy righteousness, even of thine only.*
- 17 *O God, thou hast taught me from my youth: and hitherto have I declared thy wondrous works.*
- 18 *Now also when I am old and greyheaded, O God, forsake me not; until I have shewed thy strength unto this generation, and thy power to every one that is to come.*
- 19 *Thy righteousness also, O God, is very high, who hast done great things: O God, who is like unto thee!*
- 20 *Thou, which hast shewed me great and sore troubles, shalt quicken me again, and shalt bring me up again from the depths of the earth.*
- 21 *Thou shalt increase my greatness, and comfort me on every side.*
- 22 *I will also praise thee with the psaltery, even thy truth, O my God: unto thee will I sing with the harp, O thou Holy One of Israel.*
- 23 *My lips shall greatly rejoice when I sing unto thee; and my soul, which thou hast redeemed.*
- 24 *My tongue also shall talk of thy righteousness all the day long: for they are confounded, for they are brought unto shame, that seek my hurt.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 71 is the prayer of an older believer, traditionally linked with David in his later years, perhaps amid Absalom's revolt when even a seasoned king felt the ground shift under him. It stands near the close of Book II of the Psalter as a fitting summary of a lifelong walk with God: leaned on from birth, tested by enemies who now watch for a final stumble, and still reaching for one more chapter of praise. Henry notes that grace does not retire; MacArthur-style readers see here a template for finishing well rather than fading quietly.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

The opening plea rests on long-standing refuge: be my rock and fortress, deliver me out of the hand of the wicked, for you alone have been my confidence. Righteousness, not merit, is the ground of the request—God's own character, not the psalmist's record, is what he appeals to.

Verse 5-9

The theme surfaces plainly: hope from youth, held from birth, a life that has always leaned on God and always will. Precisely because of that history, the request in verse 9 lands with force—do not cast me off in the time of old age, do not forsake me when strength fails. Aging is named as a real vulnerability, not brushed past.

Verse 10-13

Enemies read weakness as opportunity: they say God has abandoned him, and now is the moment to strike since no one is left to help. The prayer answers not with self-defense but with urgency toward God—be not far, hasten to my aid, let those who seek my hurt be brought to shame.

Verse 14-18

Continual hope answers continual threat. The psalmist commits to praising more and more, to declaring righteousness and salvation all day even though he cannot count them all. The turn in verse 18 is the psalm's heart: now that I am old and gray-headed, do not forsake me until I have shown your strength to this generation and your power to the next. Old age becomes a final commission, not a benched season.

Verse 19-21

Confidence widens into wonder: your righteousness is very high, you have done great things, who is like you? The same God who has allowed great and sore troubles is asked to revive, to lift up from the depths, and to increase comfort on every side—affliction and restoration held by the same hand.

Verse 22-24

The psalm ends in resolved praise: instruments and voice will honor the Holy One of Israel, lips will rejoice, the tongue will talk of righteousness all day. Those who sought his harm are left confounded, while he is left singing—vindication expressed not in triumphalism but in worship.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Psalm 71 teaches that faith formed in youth is meant to mature into confidence in old age, not evaporate under it. Weakness and diminishing strength do not disqualify a believer from God's care; they become the very setting in which His faithfulness is most worth declaring to the next generation. The psalmist's hope is continual because it is anchored in who God has always been, not in what his own body can still do.

Application for life today.

If you are aging, feeling sidelined, or watching your strength diminish, this psalm gives you permission to name that fear honestly to God rather than pretend it away. Consider what it means to keep declaring God's works to a younger generation even as your own capacities shrink—your testimony may matter more now than ever. Let verse 14's resolve to hope 'more and more' shape a daily habit of naming God's past faithfulness before asking for new mercy.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

- 1.** Where do you sense the fear of verse 9—being set aside or forgotten as strength fades—and how does this psalm invite you to bring that directly to God?
- 2.** What would it look like this season to 'show God's strength to this generation' (v. 18) rather than withdraw from it?
- 3.** How does remembering God's faithfulness 'from my youth' change the way you pray about a current weakness?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).